passes. It was clear almost immediately that, after six months, the tables were now turning in favour of the British.

There was a brief halt in the advance as Sale ordered his second-in-command, William Dennie, to assault one of the small mud forts that lay between the city and Akbar's camp; in the confusion Dennie – the man who had led the assault on Kandahar in 1839 and defeated Dost Mohammad at Bamiyan a year later – was shot dead as he rushed through the fort gate at the head of his men. But the advance continued unchecked. As Akbar's lines drew closer, and the Afghan guns opened up on the columns, the infantry broke into a run, then charged with fixed bayonets. Among those in the lead was Thomas Seaton. 'The columns were soon well up to the camp,' he wrote.

> We made a rush at it, and carried it without a check, the enemy flying through the grove of trees beyond. We saw large numbers of them throw themselves into the river which, swollen and rapid, destroyed the greatest portion of them. The enemy's horse hung about for some time, but our cavalry and guns making a demonstration against them they moved off, going along the banks of the stream. The whole of Akbar's camp fell into our hands. His guns, ammunition, standards, plunder – everything he had with him. The bugle soon recalled our skirmishers, and I detached with a party to fire the tents, and the huts made of boughs and reeds. They were very numerous, and the smoke of the burning proclaimed our victory to the whole valley. Numbers of camels and mounds of grain fell into our hands . . . In spite of the woeful mistake made in attacking the enemy's outpost [where Dennie had been killed] our loss was surprisingly small, amounting to only eleven men killed.[5]

It was all over by 7 a.m. The beaten and wounded Afghan besiegers were soon streaming back towards Gandamak, and by midday the British commissariat staff were already busy moving large quantities of captured grain, powder, shells and shot into the city, as well as 'a lot of fowls which were flying about loose'. 'Never was a victory so complete,' wrote a gleeful Gleig. 'Akbar and the wreck of his army fled towards Kabul, and all the chiefs of the districts in the other direction sent in their submission.'[6]

When Pollock's relief force finally marched into sight, nine days later, the garrison was able to ride out to escort them in. The Army of Retribution, expecting to see 'long beards, haggard faces and tattered garments' found instead the defenders 'all fat and rosy, in the highest health, scrupulously clean shaven and dressed as neatly as if quartered in the best regulated cantonment in India. We on the contrary, the relieving army, presented the